24ENG101 ENGLISH I

Semester I

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH
AMRITA VISHWA VIDYAPEETHAM

Syllabus

24ENG101 **English I** **2 0 0 2**

Objectives:

To help students obtain an ability to communicate fluently in English; to enable and enhance the students' skills in listening, speaking, reading, and writing; to impart an aesthetic sense and enhance creativity

CO	Course Outcomes
CO1	Demonstrate competence in the mechanics of writing
CO2	Summarise audio and written texts to convey messages effectively
CO3	Apply mechanics of writing and AI tools to draft academic and professional documents
CO4	Organise ideas and thoughts for clear written and oral communication
CO5	Critically evaluate literary texts

Unit I

Mechanics of writing - Parts of speech – use of prepositions, adjectives, adverbs and determiners – word order – collocation – concord (Subject-Verb, Pronoun-Antecedent) – kinds and patterns of sentences

Unit II

Tenses - Modal auxiliaries - Reported speech - Active and Passive Voice - Phrasal Verbs - Linkers/ Discourse Markers - Question Tags

Unit III

Pre-writing techniques - Paragraph writing – Cohesion – Development – types: definition, comparison, classification, contrast, cause and effect - Essay writing: Descriptive and Narrative - Introduction to the use of Gen AI in writing (AI tools, Do's and Don'ts while using AI, how to write prompts, etc.)

Unit IV

Listening comprehension (3 pieces – Do Schools kill creativity? By Sir Ken Robinson, Steve Jobs' 2005 Stanford Commencement Address, India Questions Dr Abdul Kalam- Aired August 2007) - Reading Comprehension – Skimming and Scanning- Inference and Deduction – Reading different kinds of material – Speaking**:** Narration of incidents / stories/ anecdotes.

Unit V

1. Shashi Tharoor – "'Kindly Adjust' to Our English
2. A.G. Gardiner – "A Fellow Traveller"
3. Ruskin Bond – "The Eyes Have It"
4. Mrinal Pande – "Girls"
5. W. H. Auden – "Unknown Citizen"
6. W H Davies - "Leisure"

References:

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4. The Week - June 03, 2018, LAST WORD; https://www.theweek.in/columns/shashi-tharoor/2018/05/25/kindly-adjust-to-our-english.html?fbclid=IwAR3IhtdXqvuV4ySECn9S7SA6HmCEYISyd1QHd3BlwKgiNKKwdkeSg3qWp-U/
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6. Ruskin Bond – *The Best of Ruskin Bond*; India Penguin. April 2016.
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11. Steve Jobs' 2005 Stanford Commencement Address. https://youtu.be/UF8uR6Z6KLc?si=1nMNYJOk3Yw7H7tF
12. India Questions Dr Abdul Kalam (aired: August 2007). https://youtu.be/erg3CmVm6M4?si=YudsxXZOFY1do91C

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‘Kindly Adjust’ to Our English

- Shashi Tharoor

I have long immodestly considered myself the inventor of the term 'prepone'. I came up with it at St Stephen’s in 1972, used it extensively in conversation and employed it in an article in JS magazine soon after. Prepone, as a back-construction from postpone, seemed so much simpler, to a teenage collegian, than saying, “could you move that appointment earlier?” or “I would like to advance that deadline”. Over the years, I was gratified to see how extensively its use had spread in India. Now, in an era where too many claim credit for other’s work, I feel it may be time to clarify the word’s origins. Is anyone aware of an earlier usage?

I ask because the persistence and survival of what is called 'Indian English' (often with a sneer, as if to differentiate it from the Queen’s “propah” English) deserves to be taken seriously. Our English is a vigorous language, which draws strength from local roots. If Americans can say 'fall' for autumn and 'gotten' for 'have got', though both are archaisms in England itself, why can’t Indians say 'furlong', 'fortnight' and 'do the needful', even if these have fallen out of use centuries ago in London? So many words in Indian English have stood up to the only test that matters—the test of time and usage. If enough people find a word or phrase useful, it is, to my mind, legitimate.

Indian English is a living, practical language, used by millions every day. Many phrases we take for granted in ordinary conversation are actually quite unusual abroad—calling elders 'auntie' or 'uncle', for instance, or using 'non-veg' to convey a willingness to eat meat. That doesn’t make them wrong, or even quaint. It just makes them Indian.

Some Indian English was created by our media—'airdash' (the chief minister airdashed to Delhi) and 'history sheeter' (“the police explained that habitual criminal X was a history sheeter”, i.e. he had a long criminal record). Some, like my 'prepone', came from school and college campuses: 'mugging' (cramming hard for an exam, with much rote learning involved) means two very

different things abroad (a criminal assault by a robber, or an elaborate and often comically exaggerated expression). When an Indian student tells a foreigner he was “mugging for an exam”, bewilderment is guaranteed.

Some Indian Englishisms are merely translated from an Indian language: “what is your good name?” is the classic, since all Bengalis have a daak naam that they are called by, and a bhalo naam (or good name) for the record. But “what is your good name?” is still the most polite form, in any version of the English language, for finding out the identity of your interlocutor.

Some Indianisms are creative uses of an ordinary English word or phrase to reflect a particularly Indian sensibility, such as “kindly adjust”, said apologetically by the seventh person squeezing onto a bench meant for four. Our matrimonial ads have created their own cultural tropes—'wheatish complexion', of course, and better still, 'traditional with modern outlook'.

But acknowledging the legitimacy of Indian English and many of its formulations doesn’t mean that “anything goes”. Some things are simply wrong. The Indian habit of saying “I will return back” is an unnecessary redundancy: if you return, you are coming back. The desi practice of using 'till' to mean 'as long as' is incorrect English; it is wrong to say “I will miss you till you are away” when you really mean is “I will miss you till you come back”! The Indian official doesn’t “waive off” a fine, he just waives it, though he could wave you off if you thank him too profusely. And, 'back side' for 'rear' causes much unwitting hilarity, as in signs proclaiming, “entry through back side only”. These can’t be justified under the rubric of Indian English. They are just bad English.

But for the rest, we have nothing to apologise about: we should defiantly celebrate their use as integral parts of our Indian English vocabulary. After all, “we are like that only”. And if you don’t like it, kindly adjust.

A FELLOW TRAVELLER

- A. G Gardiner

I do not know which of us got into the carriage first. Indeed I did not know he was in the carriage at all for some time. It was the last train from London to a Midland town—a stopping train, an infinitely leisurely train, one of those trains which give you an understanding of eternity. It was tolerably full when it started, but as we stopped at the suburban stations the travellers alighted in ones and twos, and by the time we had left the outer ring of London behind I was alone—or, rather, I thought I was alone.

There is a pleasant sense of freedom about being alone in a carriage that is jolting noisily through the night. It is liberty and unrestraint in a very agreeable form. You can do anything you like. You can talk to yourself as loud as you please and no one will hear you. You can have that argument out with Jones and roll him triumphantly in the dust without fear of a counter-stroke. You can stand on your head and no one will see you. You can sing, or dance a two-step, or practise a golf stroke, or play marbles on the floor without let or hindrance. You can open the window or shut it without provoking a protest. You can open both windows or shut both. Indeed, you can go on opening them and shutting them as a sort of festival of freedom. You can have any corner you choose and try all of them in turn. You can lie at full length on the cushions and enjoy the luxury of breaking the regulations and possibly the heart of D.O.R.A. herself. Only D.O.R.A. will not know that her heart is broken. You have escaped even D.O.R.A.

On this night I did not do any of these things. They did not happen to occur to me. What I did was much more ordinary. When the last of my fellow-passengers had gone I put down my paper, stretched my arms and my legs, stood up and looked out of the window on the calm summer night through which I was journeying, noting the pale reminiscence of day that still lingered in the northern sky; crossed the carriage and looked out of the other window; lit a cigarette, sat down and began to read again. It was then that I became aware of my fellow traveller. He came and sat on

my nose.... He was one of those wingy, nippy, intrepid insects that we call, vaguely, mosquitoes. I flicked him off my nose, and he made a tour of the compartment, investigated its three dimensions, visited each window, fluttered round the light, decided that there was nothing so interesting as that large animal in the corner, came and had a look at my neck.

I flicked him off again. He skipped away, took another jaunt round the compartment, returned, and seated himself impudently on the back of my hand. It is enough, I said; magnanimity has its limits. Twice you have been warned that I am someone in particular, that my august person resents the tickling impertinences of strangers. I assume the black cap. I condemn you to death. Justice demands it, and the court awards it. The counts against you are many. You are a vagrant; you are a public nuisance; you are travelling without a ticket; you have no meat coupon. For these and many other misdemeanours you are about to die. I struck a swift, lethal blow with my right hand. He dodged the attack with an insolent ease that humiliated me. My personal vanity was aroused. I lunged at him with my hand, with my paper; I jumped on the seat and pursued him round the lamp; I adopted tactics of feline cunning, waiting till he had alighted, approaching with a horrible stealthiness, striking with a sudden and terrible swiftness.

It was all in vain. He played with me, openly and ostentatiously, like a skilful matador finessing round an infuriated bull. It was obvious that he was enjoying himself, that it was for this that he had disturbed my repose. He wanted a little sport, and what sport like being chased by this huge, lumbering windmill of a creature, who tasted so good and seemed so helpless and so stupid? I began to enter into the spirit of the fellow. He was no longer a mere insect. He was developing into a personality, an intelligence that challenged the possession of this compartment with me on equal terms. I felt my heart warming towards him and the sense of superiority fading. How could I feel superior to a creature who was so manifestly my master in the only competition in which we had ever engaged? Why not be magnanimous again? Magnanimity and mercy were the noblest attributes of man. In the exercise of these high qualities I could recover my prestige. At present I

was a ridiculous figure, a thing for laughter and derision. By being merciful I could reassert the moral dignity of man and go back to my corner with honour. I withdraw the sentence of death, I said, returning to my seat. I cannot kill you, but I can reprieve you. I do it.

I took up my paper and he came and sat on it. Foolish fellow, I said, you have delivered yourself into my hands. I have but to give this respectable weekly organ of opinion a smack on both covers and you are a corpse, neatly sandwiched between an article on "Peace Traps" and another on "The Modesty of Mr. Hughes." But I shall not do it. I have reprieved you, and I will satisfy you that when this large animal says a thing he means it. Moreover, I no longer desire to kill you. Through knowing you better I have come to feel—shall I say?—a sort of affection for you. I fancy that St. Francis would have called you "little brother." I cannot go so far as that in Christian charity and civility. But I recognise a more distant relationship. Fortune has made us fellow travellers on this summer night. I have interested you and you have entertained me. The obligation is mutual and it is founded on the fundamental fact that we are fellow mortals. The miracle of life is ours in common and its mystery too. I suppose you don't know anything about your journey. I'm not sure that I know much about mine. We are really, when you come to think of it, a good deal alike—just apparitions that are and then are not, coming out of the night into the lighted carriage, fluttering about the lamp for a while and going out into the night again. Perhaps...

"Going on to-night, sir?" said a voice at the window. It was a friendly porter giving me a hint that this was my station. I thanked him and said I must have been dozing. And seizing my hat and stick I went out into the cool summer night. As I closed the door of the compartment I saw my fellow traveller fluttering round the lamp....

The Eyes Have It

- Ruskin Bond

I HAD THE TRAIN compartment to myself up to Rohana, then a girl got in. The couple who saw her off were probably her parents. They seemed very anxious about her comfort and the woman gave the girl detailed instructions as to where to keep her things, when not to lean out of windows, and how to avoid speaking to strangers.

They called their goodbyes and the train pulled out of the station. As I was totally blind at the time, my eyes sensitive only to light and darkness, I was unable to tell what the girl looked like. But I knew she wore slippers from the way they slapped against her heels. It would take me some time to discover something about her looks and perhaps I never would. But I liked the sound of her voice and even the sound of her slippers.

'Are you going all the way to Dehra? I asked.

I must have been sitting in a dark corner because my voice startled her. She gave a little exclamation and said, I didn't know anyone else was here.'

Well, it often happens that people with good eyesight fail to see what is right in front of them. They have too much to take in, I suppose. Whereas people who cannot see (or see very little) have to take in only the essentials, whatever registers tellingly on their remaining senses.

I didn't see you either,' I said. 'But I heard you come in.'

I wondered if I would be able to prevent her from discovering that I was blind. Provided I keep to my seat, I thought, it shouldn't be too difficult. The girl said, I am getting off at Saharanpur. My aunt is meeting me there.'

"Then I had better not get too familiar' I replied. 'Aunts are usually formidable creatures.'

'Where are you going?' she asked. 'To Dehra and then to Mussoorie.'

'Oh, how lucky you are. I wish I were going to Mussoorie. I love the hills. Especially in October.'

'Yes, this is the best time,' I said, calling on my memories. "The hills are covered with wild dahlias, the sun is delicious, and at night you can sit in front of a log fire and drink a little brandy. Most of the tourists have gone and the roads are quiet and almost deserted. Yes, October is the best time.'

She was silent. I wondered if my words had touched her or whether she thought me a romantic fool. Then I made a mistake.

'What is it like outside?' I asked.

She seemed to find nothing strange in the question. Had she noticed already that I could not see? But her next question removed my doubts.

'Why don't you look out of the window?' she asked.

I moved easily along the berth and felt for the window ledge. The window was open and I faced it, making a pretence of studying the landscape. I heard the panting of the engine, the rumble of the wheels, and, in my mind's eye I could see telegraph posts flashing by.

'Have you noticed,' I ventured, 'that the trees seem to be moving while we seem to be standing still?'

"That always happens,' she said. 'Do you see any animals?'

'No,' I answered quite confidently. I knew that there were hardly any animals left in the forests near Dehra.

I turned from the window and faced the girl and for a while we sat in silence.

'You have an interesting face,' I remarked. I was becoming quite daring but it was a safe remark. Few girls can resist flattery. She laughed pleasantly—a clear, ringing laugh.

'It's nice to be told I have an interesting face. I'm tired of people telling me I have a pretty face.'

Oh, so you do have a pretty face, thought I. And aloud I said: 'Well, an interesting face can also be pretty.'

'You are a very gallant young man' she said. 'But why are you so serious?'

I thought, then, that I would try to laugh for her, but the thought of laughter only made me feel troubled and lonely.

'We'll soon be at your station' I said.

'Thank goodness it's a short journey. I can't bear to sit in a train for more than two or three hours.'

Yet I was prepared to sit there for almost any length of time, just to listen to her talking. Her voice had the sparkle of a mountain stream. As soon as she left the train she would forget our brief encounter. But it would stay with me for the rest of the journey and for some time after.

The engine's whistle shrieked, the carriage wheels changed their sound and rhythm, the girl got up and began to collect her things. I wondered if she wore her hair in a bun or if it was plaited. Perhaps it was hanging loose over her shoulders. Or was it cut very short?

The train drew slowly into the station. Outside, there was the shouting of porters and vendors and a high-pitched female voice near the carriage door. That voice must have belonged to the girl's aunt.

'Goodbye' the girl said.

She was standing very close to me. So close that the perfume from her hair was tantalizing. I wanted to raise my hand and touch her hair but she moved away. Only the scent of perfume still lingered where she had stood.

There was some confusion in the doorway. A man, getting into the compartment, stammered an apology. Then the door banged and the world was shut out again. I returned to my berth. The guard blew his whistle and we moved off. Once again I had a game to play and a new fellow traveller.

The train gathered speed, the wheels took up their song, the carriage groaned and shook. I found the window and sat in front of it, staring into the daylight that was darkness for me.

So many things were happening outside the window. It could be a fascinating game guessing what went on out there.

The man who had entered the compartment broke into my reverie.

'You must be disappointed' he said. 'I'm not nearly as attractive a travelling companion as the one who just left.' 'She was an interesting girl' I said. 'Can you tell me—did she keep her hair long or short?'

'I don't remember' he said sounding puzzled. 'It was her eyes I noticed, not her hair. She had beautiful eyes but they were of no use to her. She was completely blind. Didn't you notice?'

Girls

- Mrinal Pande

The day we left with Ma for Nani's house, Babu broke a surahi. I don't know whether he did it on purpose or by accident but anyway the floor was flooded with water. Ma held up her sari and called Saru's mother—who was trying to eavesdrop from the adjacent room—to mop up the water because if someone were to slip and break their bones, it would be yet another problem. To Ma, everything in life was a problem. As far as she was concerned, whether we were at home or at school, ill or just playing around, we were a problem. While mopping the floor, Saru's mother looked up at Ma and asked, 'This time you'll be away for at least three months won't you?' Ma squatted down and said, 'Yes they won't allow me to come back sooner.' She turned to me and ordered me to go out and play. I always seemed to turn up at the wrong time and at the wrong place. As I was leaving the room, I managed to pick up a piece of the broken surahi which I enjoyed sucking and I overheard Ma addressing either Saru's mother or the cobwebs hanging from the roof, 'I hope it's a boy this time. It will relieve me of the nuisance of going through another pregnancy.' I could just imagine Saru's mother, in her usual manner, shaking her head and saying, 'Why not? Why not?'

When we reached the station I scrambled on to the train, fought my way through people and luggage, and secured a place next to the window. Triumphantly, I stuck my tongue out at everyone and went, 'Eee...eee.' But when I noticed Ma's gaze turning towards me, I immediately started chanting the alphabet, 'Eee for Imli, Eee for Eekh.' Ma was actually not looking at me though, because she was preoccupied with all her problems. She had to mind the luggage, the wobbling surahi, the three of us, and cope with the exhaustion of pregnancy as well. At one of the stations we bought a lot of samosas filled with chillies. Just when we were buying them a woman was making her child urinate through the next window. The sight made me feel quite nauseous and I couldn't eat my samosa so I gave it to Ma instead.

Meanwhile I crushed a piece of potato which was lying on the seat into the shape of an insect, to frighten my younger sister. She screamed, Ma smacked me and I started to cry as well. My elder sister was irritated and said, 'Oh what a nuisance you are!' Despite her irritation I knew that it was only my elder sister who really loved me, everyone else was horrible.

Mama was waiting to receive us at the station. On the way to Nani's, I sat next to Mami and noticed the rubies in her ear lobes bobbing up and down while she chewed paan. Everytime the driver pressed the jeep's horn, my sisters and I would scream in unison, 'Poo...poo.' The driver was amused at our screaming and when we reached the house he lifted me and my younger sister out of the jeep. He had a huge moustache which smelt of tea and bidis and wore a uniform made of coarse wool, which tickled me and made me feel sleepy. When the surahi was lifted out of the jeep, it overturned, and once again there was water everywhere. This incident reminded me so much of Babu that, absent-mindedly, I trod hard on my younger sister's sandal, nearly tripping her up. 'You are the cause of all my problems!' Ma hissed at me through tightly clenched teeth so that no one could hear. She then grabbed hold of my arm, as if to prevent me from falling over, but actually pressed it so hard that my shoulder hurt.

I thought of Babu because, whenever we came to Nani's house he never accompanied us. And as soon as we arrived, Ma would be lost in the company of Masis, Mamis, Nani, and old maidservants. If you tried going near her during the day someone or other would say, 'Let the poor thing have some rest at least while she is here.' Ma too would put on a pathetic act as if we always harassed her at home. I felt disgusted at the thought of entering Nani's house, so I deliberately loitered near the bushes. Then I heard someone mentioning my name inside the house and saying, 'Now where has she disappeared?'

I entered the house along with the dog and saw Nani sitting with Mama's son on her lap. As soon as she saw the dog she shooed it away because, to her, all animals were untouchables. The dog, used to being reprimanded, tucked its tail between its legs and went out. I was told to bend down

and touch Nani's feet. Someone from the family said, 'Not like that...bend properly. You are born a girl and you will have to bend for the rest of your life so you might as well learn.' Nani blessed me by waving her hand over my bowed back and said, 'This girl hasn't grown taller. Who would believe she is eight years old?'

'Oh what a nuisance this is!', Ma kept complaining. The old lady from the neighbourhood who had come to see Ma told Nani, 'This time Lali will definitely have a boy. Just look at her complexion—when she was expecting the girls it was pink but now it has a tinge of yellow. I am sure it will be a boy this time.'

'Who knows perhaps even this time...', moaned Ma as she put on a pathetic expression and began paring her nails.

'Is there anyone to cook for your husband?' asked the old lady. Her question set me thinking about Babu, how good he smelt and the softness of his lap. And how, when we came here, Ma did not allow us to lie in her lap for too long and complained, 'Ugh! Oh! My bones are aching, my sari is all crushed. Get up now. I have such a lot of work to do and to top it all there is this huge nuisance. Come on get up.'

Nani folded her hands and prayed, 'Oh Goddess protect my honour! At least this time let her take a son back from her parents' home'. At the end of her prayer she dried her tears with her pallu.

From the corner of my eyes I could see that my sisters were fast asleep. All the lights had been switched off and the room was flooded with moonlight. Tulsa Dai was applying oil to the soles of Ma's feet and saying, 'if it's a boy, this time I will demand a sari with stainless steel zari.'

'If I have a boy this time, then I will be relieved of this burden forever', she tells Tulsa Dai and then adds, 'You can go home now, your children must be waiting for you. Be sure you put the oil vessel under the bed, otherwise one of these kids will kick it over in the morning....', ah a bad omen. Whenever Ma left a sentence unfinished, it seemed to loom in the air like the ticking of the

clock. I wonder why grown-ups always complete their sentences when they are talking about pleasant things but always leave them unfinished if it is something unpleasant. Like, 'Ah, a woman's fate....', Or, 'Oh three girls....', There's always a silence after these half statements.

There's a bright star in the sky. Is that the Dhruva star? Babu used to say that if I worked hard I could become anything I wanted, just as Dhruva became a star. 'But I can't become a boy, can I?' I once asked obstinately. I was surprised at Babu's reaction when he put on a serious look and said sternly, 'Don't argue with your elders now.' I find it difficult to understand them. My elder sister says one should never trust grownups because if they want to know something they will prise it out of you by hook or by crook, but they themselves will never tell you a thing.

It's true nobody ever tells us anything. In this place it's when we go to sleep that the world of the elders awakens, opening like a magic casket. I want to stay awake and listen. I don't know why, I fall asleep halfway through. I wonder whose voice it is now, it seems as if someone is crying in suppressed tones. Is it Chotti Masi? 'I don't get as much respect as a dog does in that house', she tells Ma. I wonder where she is treated worse than a dog, then I hear Ma telling her, 'All of us suffer like that, one just has to endure it.' My eyes shut and I fall asleep.

The next morning, when everyone is having breakfast, I ask Ma what 'endure' means. I remind her by asking, what does Chotti Masi have to endure? I get one tight slap, then another, but before Ma strikes me again, Mami saves me and says, 'Let it be. She is only a child after all.' 'She is no child, she is a witch', says Ma as her stomach wobbles in anger. 'She's always listening on the sly to elders talking. Heaven knows what will become of her.'

When I go into the garden, my elder sister throws the flowers she has gathered at me. 'Oh...you! I have told you a hundred times not to question grown-ups. If you keep on like this, one day these people will beat you so hard you will die.' 'I will ask questions. I will. I will', I answer, crying. 'Then go and die', says my elder sister and continues to thread a garland for Nani's Gopalji. Nani

stands by her and says loudly, 'You are my precious Lakshmi', with the intention that I should hear. In the afternoons, I tell the younger children horror stories of ghosts and demons who lived in the walnut tree. I tell them that if they should wake up at twelve o'clock on a full-moon night, they would see children being bathed in blood. They would also hear the ghosts speaking through their noses, which at first is difficult to follow. The children follow me all over the house like mice following the Pied Piper.

'Move aside', says Hari's mother, who is carrying a tray laden with glasses of tea into the room. 'Move. This is not for you, it's for the grown-ups. Move out of my way.' Hari's mother's nose is like a frog's and her eyebrows meet above her nose. Whenever she laughs her cheeks hang loose like bats. 'Do move aside', she says to me again. 'I won't', I say and try to block her way. 'I'll only move if you say girls are nice.' 'All right, all right, I have said it, so now move out of the way', says Hari's mother. 'No', I persist, 'say it properly.'

'Oh Hari's Ma, what's happening?' asked Maasi irritably from the room., 'Are you going to bring the tea next year or what?' Hari's mother knits her thick eyebrows together and says, 'This Lali's middle daughter won't let me...', She starts laughing, and as she does so her frog- like nose bobs up and down. I can hear Ma naming me and saying, 'That girl must be harassing her. She was born only to plague my life.' Someone in the room advises her that she should not get angry in her condition.

For a long time I sit outside the house watching the birds flying and wishing that I had been born a bird. 'Do mother birds too think their girl birds are inferior?', I wonder. Then I hear a voice calling, 'Where has she gone?' and I know someone is searching for me. I hide behind the wall where no one can ever find me. I wish that somewhere, anywhere, I could find that magic betel nut which would make me invisible as soon as I put it in my mouth. What wonderful fun that would be!

'Where are you? Girls?' calls Nani, with a tray of crimson powder in her hands. In front of her there is a dish of halwa and a plate filled with puris she has prepared as offerings to the Devi on Ashtami day. A mat has been spread in front of her for us to sit on. 'Come on girls, let me put the teeka on your foreheads.' She lights the camphor for aarti. 'Come now, let me do aarti to all of you.' My two sisters and Maama's beautiful daughters sit cross-legged in front of Nani. She puts a teeka on each forehead and then rings a bell. Exactly like the guard on the train. After the bell rings, she blows the conch, 'Poo...ooo'. I am suddenly transformed into a railway engine and race around the ledge of the courtyard. I shout, 'Come on, pay your fares to go to Calcutta. Poo...ooo.'

In the background, I hear Nani saying, 'Come on dear, let me put the teeka on you. You are my Kanyakumari aren't you?'

'No', I retort, 'I am an engine.' Mami's son claps his hands with excitement and says, 'Oh, an engine an engine!'

Suddenly I see Ma waddling towards me with a clenched fist and my stomach grows tight with fear. Her face is filled with rage. 'I'll make an engine out of you this very minute.'

The elderly neighbour intervenes, catches hold of Ma's hand and says, 'Have you gone mad Lali?' She signals to me to obey and adds, 'She's after all a child, a Kanyakumari. Today is Ashtami, the Devi's day; you mustn't hit a Kanyakumari, it is a sin.'

I jump down from the ledge with a thud and see Nani serving the other girls halwa-puri with the tightly clenched mouth.

'Go on. Take the prasad from Nani. Why do you make your mother cry when she is in this condition?' Masi asked me irritably.

'When you people don't love girls, why do you pretend to worship them?' My voice breaks into a sob and I feel so furious with myself that I want to swallow the burning camphor to choke my

treacherous throat. I want to ask, 'Why', again, but don't risk it because I am afraid I will start to cry. I don't want to cry in front of them.

Hari's mother addresses the wall saying, 'Just listen to her. What a temper for a girl to show!'

Nani is distributing a rupee and a quarter to each girl. I notice the mark of the crimson powder on the tip of her thumb like a bloodstain.

I start moving back towards the wall and screaming, 'I don't want all the halwa-puri teeka or money. I don't want to be a goddess.' I screamed so loudly that the pigeons pecking at the scattered grain in the courtyard took off in a flurry as if a bullet had been fired somewhere.

Unknown Citizen

- W. H. Auden

He was found by the Bureau of Statistics to be

One against whom there was no official complaint,

And all the reports on his conduct agree

That, in the modern sense of an old-fashioned word, he was a saint,

For in everything he did he served the Greater Community.

Except for the War till the day he retired

He worked in a factory and never got fired,

But satisfied his employers, Fudge Motors Inc.

Yet he wasn't a scab or odd in his views,

For his Union reports that he paid his dues,

(Our report on his Union shows it was sound)

And our Social Psychology workers found

That he was popular with his mates and liked a drink.

The Press are convinced that he bought a paper every day

And that his reactions to advertisements were normal in every way.

Policies taken out in his name prove that he was fully insured,

And his Health-card shows he was once in hospital but left it cured.

Both Producers Research and High-Grade Living declare

He was fully sensible to the advantages of the Instalment Plan

And had everything necessary to the Modern Man,

A phonograph, a radio, a car and a frigidaire.

Our researchers into Public Opinion are content

That he held the proper opinions for the time of year;

When there was peace, he was for peace: when there was war, he went.

He was married and added five children to the population,

Which our Eugenist says was the right number for a parent of his generation.

And our teachers report that he never interfered with their education.

Was he free? Was he happy? The question is absurd:

Had anything been wrong, we should certainly have heard.

Leisure

- W H Devis

WHAT is this life if, full of care,

We have no time to stand and stare?—

No time to stand beneath the boughs,

And stare as long as sheep and cows:

No time to see, when woods we pass,

Where squirrels hide their nuts in grass:

No time to see, in broad daylight,

Streams full of stars, like skies at night:

No time to turn at Beauty's glance,

And watch her feet, how they can dance:

No time to wait till her mouth can

Enrich that smile her eyes began?

A poor life this if, full of care,

We have no time to stand and stare.